



months, when I started playing tennis again, I had no pain. That is where the belief came back again. I could enjoy tennis again and play without any pain. I didn't think that day would ever come. Today, I am happily playing without any painkillers," he added.

It is not just the overcoming of physical pain and setbacks that embody Bopanna's indomitable spirit, but also his mental resilience. Following his triumph in Melbourne, he admitted to wanting to quit the sport a couple of years ago because of an extended barren run of about four-five months.

But patience is a virtue that has stood him in good stead. After all, it took him 13 years to reach his

second Slam doubles final (2010 US Open to the 2023 US Open), a period that also coincided with a 10-year-long wait for his two previous career-high rankings (No. 3 in 2013 to No.3 in 2023).

That wait bore fruit, but time seems to be running out as 'the grand old man of Indian tennis' awaits a partner for the upcoming Paris Olympics.

"I would love to play with one of the guys in a few tournaments. Unfortunately, I have told them they need to get their ranking up. We won't get into any of the Masters series or the ATP 500s because all the guys ranked today are 60 and below.

Unfortunately, there is no chance



CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

Became only the third Indian to win a men's doubles Grand Slam title, taking the Australian Open crown with partner Matthew Ebden

At 43, he also became the oldest Grand Slam champion in men's tennis

Was playing his third men's doubles final at Grand Slam events, having ended runner-up at US Open twice (2013, 2023)
Oldest player to become number one in men's doubles rankings



Old pals: Indian tennis veterans Rohan Bopanna and Leander Paes in conversation with each other on the night of the Sportstar Aces Awards function in Mumbai. K. R. DEEPAK

of getting into the mixed doubles because the only way to get in is combined ranking. Top-10 only gets you a partner for the men's doubles. So, mixed doubles is out of the question because there is nobody from the women's side ranked that high," he said.

He also urged the players not to miss the upcoming clay-court season in order to prepare for a surface that is not typically preferred by the Indians.

It is said that being at the top can be a lonely experience in elite sports. At 'Level 43', as he likes to refer to his age-defying success, Bopanna will hope for someone to take on the baton. That would be another burden off his shoulder.